

November 18: China and its EVD

A consortium of Chinese companies announced the release of the EVD disc format to combat the aging DVD. Enhanced Versatile Disc is not really a different disc format like HD-DVD or Blu-ray, but more of a playback format. Instead of using MPEG-2 compression for video, it uses its own algorithm to store higher-definition movies on regular DVDs. The Chinese consortium was backed by the Chinese government to create EVD because of the royalty costs associated with DVDs. Basically, for every DVD player that's manufactured, the maker has to pay about \$15 (about Rs 600) in licensing fees for MPEG-2, the Content Scrambling System (the ability to read digitally copy-protected DVDs), Macrovision (an analogue copy-protection system), and all the various surround-sound filters. EVD, on the other hand, costs hardware manufacturers just \$2 (Rs 80) per hardware player in terms of licensing. Like HD-DVD, EVD is capable of 1080i (1920 x 1080) high-definition resolutions, though Blu-Ray is 1080p-capable. Currently, it's all HD-DVD and Blu-Ray, though, and as of 2007, EVD remains pretty much confined to China—which is a big enough market anyway.

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April 1: Gmail!

April Fool's day, Google announces the release of Gmail. Google claims that the idea of Gmail came from complaints of regular e-mail users, whining about how hard it was to find older e-mails, and how the space limits were irritating. Gmail was born from a programmer's mandatory 20-per cent-time—everyone in Google is encouraged to spend a day a week on personal projects. Google also hit the jackpot by initially making Gmail an “invitation-only” service. Great human psyche study there—announce the release of something, make it invite only so that everyone knows that they can't have one, and obviously, everyone then wants one at any cost. Another innovation that Google made with Gmail was to do